those actions, of course. Gokhale's own previous work *The Puffin Mahabharata* (2009) has been acclaimed as a rare young readers' version that does not seek to sanitise the events of the epic. Even now, she considers it her finest work ("I was overwhelmed by all the hurt, all the inequity, all the greatness in this epic").

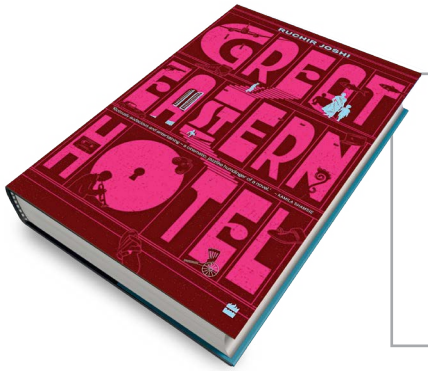
"The things that transform you... when you begin those enterprises, you never realise that they are going to transform you," says Gokhale. "Through the 2000s, David Davidar, then with Penguin, commissioned me to write *The Book of Shiva* and then *The Puffin Mahabharata* for young readers. For the latter he told me, it's going to be 40,000 words and you'll give it to me in six months; I foolishly said yes. But the abbreviated timeline made me read so much, everything on the Mahabharata, it was the most important literary experience of my life."

Life on Mars is a great introduction to the style and the philosophical preoccupations of one of India's pre-eminent English-language writers. These 15 stories display an impressive range in terms of both form and content, and connoisseurs of short fiction would be well advised to pick it up. ■

–Aditya Mani Jha

OH! CALCUTTA

Ruchir Joshi's Great Eastern Hotel *is a sweeping historical saga which interleaves several strands of narrative within shifting layers of time*



GREAT EASTERN HOTEL
By Ruchir Joshi
4TH ESTATE/ HARPERCOLLINS
₹1,499; 920 pages

The novel takes the shape of a vast luxury hotel, situated in Calcutta towards the end of World War II. The characters function like doors into the building. Through them, the sights, sounds and especially the scents of a bygone era flicker to life with the intimacy of dreams.

The main doors into the edifice are the young revolutionary Nirupama "Niru" Majumdar, Imogen Snell, the adventurous Englishwoman and Kedar Lahiri, the artist-playboy affectionately nicknamed "Zamindear". There are two types of secret entrance. On one floor, there are the British intelligence officers struggling to predict where, how and, especially, if the Japanese will launch an attack on Calcutta's port. On another corridor altogether and along all manner of back stairs is Gopal, the ambitious young pickpocket who will pick not only our pockets but our hearts too.

The interleaving of many strands of narrative within shifting layers of time is managed with a filmmaker's ease. The opening scene is set in 1951, jump-cuts to the river of grieving humanity that attended Rabindranath Tagore's death, bounces forward to mid-seventies London where a young man is documenting the final months of a famous Indian artist's life, then back to the funeral.

Two British officers flying at night over the giant city in wartime black-out garb spot the dome of the Victoria Memorial glittering like an immense marble egg, a beacon to any would-be Japanese bombers

I read the novel out of sequence, attempting to second-guess the plot, while wallowing in the Cinerama-style descriptions, 360° through all the senses. The absolute immersion in an ethos unfamiliar to most modern readers is, it seems to me, the true purpose of the novel, rather than what happens and to whom. There's a playful edge to the writing as if the author is constantly whispering in the reader's ear, "Stop being stuffy! Just enjoy the ride!"

I loved the great Railway Station spectacles best. The chaos, the crush of bodies, the clothes, the smells and the social drama of Indian royalty being herded into a coach, while liveried bodies hold back the common masses! Another fabulous scene is the one in which Deyton and Lambert, two British officers flying at night over the giant city in wartime black-out garb, spot the dome of the Victoria Memorial glittering like an immense marble egg, a beacon to any would-be Japanese bombers.

As for Gopal-of-the-many-aliases, his sensitivity to so many levels of delight and horror makes him a type of creature-cam for the carnival of humanity within which he makes a living. He plunges in where the rest of us would rather shy away, returning with jewel-like insights and wisdom.

As a non-Bengali with a mere tourist-level fondness for Calcutta, I found the Bangla-inflected dialogue annoying. For me, Imogen came across as the most relatable character. All the other non-browns were too Central Casting to take seriously. One of them develops a forbidden passion for spicy street food—and survives!—while I passed out from the sheer unlikelihood.

Reading *Great Eastern Hotel* is like being plugged into multiple levels of consciousness through all available orifices. A wild romp that ends with the scent of river water in your nose and the breath of a flute in your ears. ■

–Manjula Padmanabhan